

Social Worker

FF11 Social work and support services · ISCO-08 2635 · CBS 1021 Maatschappelijk werkers · seniority medior ·
 Also known as: Social Worker, Community Social Worker

Supports citizens with questions across several life domains at once, refers them to suitable help and works with other organisations in the neighbourhood.

The social worker moves between light support and complex multi problem situations. The job title covers a wide spectrum in practice, so two social workers with the same title can have very different task packages. That difference often remains unnamed in job postings.

Key figures for this profile

24 skills · 7 competencies to measure · 4 knockout skills · centre of gravity: Collaboration and interpersonal effectiveness 28%, Professional knowledge domains 21%, Communication and influence 17%

1 Competencies to measure

These are the behavioural and ability constructs in this profile. Each one shows which hrmforce questionnaire measures it.

Competencies to measure	Target level	hrmforce instrument	Assessment method	Behavioural anchor at target level
interpersonal sensitivity Competency (50-framework): Sensitiviteit Knockout	 N4	Big Fifty, 360 Feedback, Kleurenprofiel (Jung)	Persoonlijkheidsvragenlijst	Names observed tension or reticence during a conversation and adapts tone, pace and wording accordingly.

Competencies to measure	Target level	hrmforce instrument	Assessment method	Behavioural anchor at target level
Listening and probing Competency (50-framework): Luisteren	 N4	Big Fifty, 360 Feedback	360 feedback	Summarises both the content and the feeling of the other party and probes until the real interest behind the request becomes visible.
integrity and dependability Competency (50-framework): Integriteit	 N4	Big Fifty (schaal Integriteit), 360 Feedback, Structureerd interview	Persoonlijkheidsvragenlijst	Reports a possible conflict of interest on own initiative and asks for review before a decision is taken.
Stress tolerance Competency (50-framework): Stressbestendigheid	 N4	Big Fifty, 15PF, Mentale Weerbaarheid (4C)	Persoonlijkheidsvragenlijst	Keeps working in a structured way at peak load, keeps agreements with clients clear and flags early which results are at risk.
Managing boundaries and energy Competency (50-framework): Stressbestendigheid	 N3	Big Fifty, Pulse Survey, Ontwikkelgesprek	Structureerd interview	Deliberately alternates demanding and lighter tasks, declines extra work with reasons and keeps own diary within the agreed hours.

Competencies to measure	Target level	hrmforce instrument	Assessment method	Behavioural anchor at target level
Safety awareness Competency (50-framework): Discipline		Big Fifty, Competency Check	Situational Judgement Test	Recognises unsafe situations in own process, intervenes and addresses colleagues without bringing the work to a halt.
Improvising within boundaries Competency (50-framework): Creativiteit		Competency Check, 360 Feedback	Situational Judgement Test	Chooses an interim solution within the rules when something fails or an unexpected request arrives, and records afterwards what deviated.

2 Full skill profile

Every skill in this profile, sorted by weight. The behavioural anchor under each skill belongs to the target level.

T	Skill	Target level	Weight	Knockout	Assessment method	hrmforce instrument
V	Conversation management Leads conversations with opposing interests at board level, develops conversation models for the organisation and tests them against practice.	 N5	5	yes	Assessment center	Communicatiestijlen, Competency Check
G	interpersonal sensitivity Names observed tension or reticence during a conversation and adapts tone, pace and wording accordingly.	 N4	5	yes	Persoonlijkheidsvragenlijst	Big Fifty, 360 Feedback, Kleurenprofiel (Jung)
V	de-escalating and setting limits States which limit is being crossed when behaviour is unwanted, what the consequence is, and ends the conversation when needed.	 N4	5	yes	Situational Judgement Test	Conflictstijlen, Big Fifty, Mentale Weerbaarheid (4C)

T	Skill	Target level	Weight	Knockout	Assessment method	hrmforce instrument
V	Support in disability care Independently attunes support to the client's level and behaviour and involves the personal network in choices.	 N4	5	yes	Praktijkobservatie	Werkproef, Competency Check
G	Listening and probing Summarises both the content and the feeling of the other party and probes until the real interest behind the request becomes visible.	 N4	4	no	360 feedback	Big Fifty, 360 Feedback
G	integrity and dependability Reports a possible conflict of interest on own initiative and asks for review before a decision is taken.	 N4	4	no	Persoonlijkheidsvragenlijst	Big Fifty (schaal Integriteit), 360 Feedback, Structureerd interview
G	Stress tolerance Keeps working in a structured way at peak load, keeps agreements with clients clear and flags early which results are at risk.	 N4	4	no	Persoonlijkheidsvragenlijst	Big Fifty, 15PF, Mentale Weerbaarheid (4C)

T	Skill	Target level	Weight	Knockout	Assessment method	hrmforce instrument
G	Managing boundaries and energy Deliberately alternates demanding and lighter tasks, declines extra work with reasons and keeps own diary within the agreed hours.	 N3	4	no	Structureerd interview	Big Fifty, Pulse Survey, Ontwikkelgesprek
V	Methodical care process and record keeping Independently draws up a care plan with measurable goals, evaluates it periodically and adjusts it when the care need changes.	 N3	4	no	Portfolio/bewijsstuk	Portfolio, Kennistoets (klantspecifiek)
V	Problem analysis Splits a recurring complaint into possible causes, tests these with own data and names the most likely cause.	 N3	3	no	Assessment center	Competency Check, Ability Scan

T	Skill	Target level	Weight	Knockout	Assessment method	hrmforce instrument
V	Information gathering and filtering Chooses sources independently for an open question, filters out duplicate and outdated data and justifies that choice.	 N3	3	no	Werkproef	Competency Check, Werkproef
V	Correspondence and record keeping Formulates answers to unusual questions independently, records the considerations briefly and keeps the file complete and up to date.	 N3	3	no	Werkproef	Werkproef
V	collaborating in chains and alliances Aligns working methods and handover moments with partner organisations and resolves bottlenecks in the cooperation with them.	 N3	3	no	Assessment center	Competency Check, 360 Feedback

T	Skill	Target level	Weight	Knockout	Assessment method	hrmforce instrument
V	representing interests Advocates a position with decision makers, supports it with facts and interests, and negotiates a feasible outcome.	 N3	3	no	Assessment center	Communicatiestijlen, Competency Check
V	working with difference and diversity of perspective Deliberately gathers diverging angles on an issue, weighs them and accounts for which insights end up in the solution.	 N3	3	no	Situational Judgement Test	Big Fifty, Kleurenprofiel (Jung), 360 Feedback
V	Reflecting on own practice Takes time to review difficult situations, looks for patterns in own conduct and records one improvement point in writing.	 N3	3	no	360 feedback	360 Feedback, Ontwikkelgesprek

T	Skill	Target level	Weight	Knockout	Assessment method	hrmforce instrument
K	GDPR and privacy in practice Judges in own processes whether a legal basis exists, applies data minimisation and handles requests from data subjects correctly.	 N3	3	no	Kennistoets	Kennistoets (klantspecifiek)
V	Safe lifting and moving in care Independently selects technique and aid for a client with limited mobility and instructs colleagues on the spot.	 N3	3	no	Praktijkobservatie	Werkproef
V	Public service delivery to citizens Independently handles applications with exceptions, explains the outcome in plain language and monitors the deadlines.	 N3	3	no	Werkproef	Werkproef, Kennistoets (klantspecifiek)

T	Skill	Target level	Weight	Knockout	Assessment method	hrmforce instrument
G	Safety awareness Recognises unsafe situations in own process, intervenes and addresses colleagues without bringing the work to a halt.		3	no	Situational Judgement Test	Big Fifty, Competency Check
V	Advisory skill Reframes the question behind the question, offers two supported options with consequences and agrees a decision moment.		2	no	Assessment center	Competency Check, Structureerd interview
G	Improvising within boundaries Chooses an interim solution within the rules when something fails or an unexpected request arrives, and records afterwards what deviated.		2	no	Situational Judgement Test	Competency Check, 360 Feedback

T	Skill	Target level	Weight	Knockout	Assessment method	hrmforce instrument
K	Knowledge of grants and schemes Independently assesses a complex application, tests the budget against the scheme and drafts the award decision.	 N3	2	no	Kennistoets	Kennistoets (klantspecifiek)
V	Working with digital devices and applications Opens and uses the prescribed applications for own tasks and asks for help whenever an unfamiliar message appears.	 N2	2	no	Werkproef	Kennistoets (klantspecifiek), Werkproef

3 Levels per seniority

The same profile with the job family seniority adjustment applied. Target levels are clamped to 1 to 5.

Skill	junior	medior	senior
Conversation management	N5	N5	N5
interpersonal sensitivity	N3	N4	N5
de-escalating and setting limits	N3	N4	N5
Support in disability care	N3	N4	N5
Listening and probing	N3	N4	N5
integrity and dependability	N3	N4	N5
Stress tolerance	N3	N4	N5
Managing boundaries and energy	N2	N3	N4
Methodical care process and record keeping	N2	N3	N4
Problem analysis	N2	N3	N4
Information gathering and filtering	N2	N3	N4
Correspondence and record keeping	N2	N3	N4
collaborating in chains and alliances	N2	N3	N4
representing interests	N2	N3	N4
working with difference and diversity of perspective	N2	N3	N4
Reflecting on own practice	N2	N3	N4
GDPR and privacy in practice	N2	N3	N4
Safe lifting and moving in care	N2	N3	N4
Public service delivery to citizens	N2	N3	N4
Safety awareness	N2	N3	N4
Advisory skill	N2	N3	N4
Improvising within boundaries	N2	N3	N4
Knowledge of grants and schemes	N3	N3	N3
Working with digital devices and applications	N1	N2	N3

4 The proficiency scale

Level	Label	Autonomy	Complexity	Scope	Depth of knowledge
N1	Guided	works under supervision and follows instruction	routine, one variable at a time	own task	basic understanding of terminology
N2	Applying	works independently within set frameworks	familiar situations with limited variation	own role	working knowledge, applies standard approach
N3	Proficient	sets own approach and seeks input proactively	several variables, some ambiguity	own team or process	thorough knowledge, weighs alternatives
N4	Advanced	directs others and decides on the approach	complex, with conflicting interests	several teams or a department	in-depth knowledge, advises others
N5	Leading	sets the standard and the policy	strategic, under high uncertainty	organisation, value chain or profession	authority, advances the profession

5 Behavioural anchors per skill

Anchors sit at N1, N3 and N5. N2 and N4 are deliberately not anchored: raters interpolate between them, following the O*NET convention.

Skill	N1	N3	N5
Conversation management Opening, steering and closing a conversation purposefully by asking questions, summarising and making concrete agreements about what happens next.	Follows a prepared list of questions, asks them in the given order and records the agreements that were made.	Chooses a fitting question type for each phase, summarises along the way and steers the conversation back to its goal when it drifts.	Leads conversations with opposing interests at board level, develops conversation models for the organisation and tests them against practice.
interpersonal sensitivity Noticing verbal and non-verbal signals from others, naming what stands out and adjusting own behaviour accordingly during the contact.	Notices when a conversation partner disengages or hesitates and asks whether the explanation is clear.	Names observed tension or reticence during a conversation and adapts tone, pace and wording accordingly.	Trains others in recognising social signals and uses that insight when designing sensitive change processes across the organisation.
de-escalating and setting limits Reducing rising tension or unwanted behaviour by staying calm, stating the limit clearly and steering or ending the conversation.	Stays calm when facing an angry reaction, lets the other person speak and calls in a colleague or manager.	States which limit is being crossed when behaviour is unwanted, what the consequence is, and ends the conversation when needed.	Establishes organisation-wide agreements on transgressive behaviour, arranges support and follow-up, and holds managers to that line.

Skill	N1	N3	N5
Support in disability care Supports people with an intellectual or physical disability in daily activities, communication and day programmes, attuned to their capabilities.	Supports a client with daily activities under supervision and follows the agreements set out in the support plan.	Independently attunes support to the client's level and behaviour and involves the personal network in choices.	Develops support methods for the target group, grounds them in professional literature and guides teams through severe behavioural issues.
Listening and probing Taking in the message of the other party fully, checking whether it is understood correctly and using targeted questions to surface underlying interests and assumptions.	Lets the other person finish speaking, takes notes and afterwards asks about anything that stayed unclear.	Summarises both the content and the feeling of the other party and probes until the real interest behind the request becomes visible.	Picks up sensitive signals in conversations with directors and supervisors and uses them to adjust organisational policy in good time.
integrity and dependability Acting in line with applicable standards and agreements, also without supervision, and being transparent about own interests, mistakes and doubtful cases.	Keeps to agreements and rules of conduct made and reports an own mistake to the manager.	Reports a possible conflict of interest on own initiative and asks for review before a decision is taken.	Sets the organisation's integrity standards, enforces them also with influential parties and explains the resulting choices publicly.
Stress tolerance Keeps delivering work of the same quality under time pressure, opposition or unexpected turns and maintains a businesslike tone with others.	Keeps working on the current task as pressure rises and asks the supervisor which task can wait.	Keeps working in a structured way at peak load, keeps agreements with clients clear and flags early which results are at risk.	Keeps the organisation workable in crises, takes decisions under high uncertainty and sets the standard for composed action under pressure.
Managing boundaries and energy Distributes own effort across the working week, says no to work that does not fit with reasons, and arranges variety between demanding and lighter tasks.	Reports to the supervisor when tasks no longer fit within working hours and follows the choice that is made.	Deliberately alternates demanding and lighter tasks, declines extra work with reasons and keeps own diary within the agreed hours.	Sets agreements across the organisation on sustainable effort and workload distribution and holds managers to compliance with them.
Methodical care process and record keeping Works through the steps of clarifying the care question, setting goals, planning, delivering and evaluating, and records these in the client file.	Records care delivered and observations in the file on the same day, using the standard reporting format.	Independently draws up a care plan with measurable goals, evaluates it periodically and adjusts it when the care need changes.	Develops the organisation's record keeping and reporting policy and leads the introduction of a new methodical care standard.

Skill	N1	N3	N5
Problem analysis Breaks a problem into parts, separates causes from effects and states which information is needed to move forward.	States precisely what deviates in a malfunction and which data are missing, and puts this to the supervisor.	Splits a recurring complaint into possible causes, tests these with own data and names the most likely cause.	Traces persistent organisational problems back to a few root causes and sets the analysis method that other teams will use.
Information gathering and filtering Searches purposefully for data in several sources, selects what is relevant to the question and leaves other information out.	Looks up the requested data in the designated sources and delivers them in full and with source references.	Chooses sources independently for an open question, filters out duplicate and outdated data and justifies that choice.	Designs the information flows for the whole field, decides which sources are authoritative and cuts redundant reporting.
Correspondence and record keeping Drafting business letters, emails and conversation records and filing them so that the handling remains traceable later for colleagues and regulators.	Sends standard letters from the system, saves attachments in the agreed location and notes the date of dispatch.	Formulates answers to unusual questions independently, records the considerations briefly and keeps the file complete and up to date.	Designs the correspondence and archiving standard for the organisation, checks compliance and accounts for file quality during an external audit.
collaborating in chains and alliances Working with external parties towards a shared result by agreeing and tracking roles, information exchange and responsibilities between organisations.	Performs an own task within a chain agreement and reports to the contact person what does not fit.	Aligns working methods and handover moments with partner organisations and resolves bottlenecks in the cooperation with them.	Builds alliances with parties that hold differing interests and establishes governance and result agreements for the whole chain.
representing interests Putting forward the interest of a group, client or organisation on their behalf with others and obtaining support or a decision for it.	Passes a question from a colleague or client to the right person and reports the answer back.	Advocates a position with decision makers, supports it with facts and interests, and negotiates a feasible outcome.	Represents the organisational interest with public authorities or sector bodies and thereby influences regulation or sector-wide agreements.
working with difference and diversity of perspective Making differences in working methods, background knowledge and insight within a group visible and using them to reach better solutions.	Asks about a colleague's different approach how it works and why it was chosen.	Deliberately gathers diverging angles on an issue, weighs them and accounts for which insights end up in the solution.	Arranges that teams routinely include dissent and different angles and tests the effect on the quality of decisions.

Skill	N1	N3	N5
Reflecting on own practice Looks back on own work in a structured way, names the effect of choices made and formulates one concrete point to do differently.	Answers the questions of the supervisor after a task about what went well and what was difficult.	Takes time to review difficult situations, looks for patterns in own conduct and records one improvement point in writing.	Builds reflection into work processes as a standard step, guides peer review across the organisation and keeps difficult assumptions open for discussion.
GDPR and privacy in practice Knows privacy legislation requirements for own work, which legal basis and retention period apply and recognises when notification is required.	Processes personal data only according to the applicable work instruction and refers doubtful cases to the privacy officer.	Judges in own processes whether a legal basis exists, applies data minimisation and handles requests from data subjects correctly.	Sets privacy policy, decides on high risk processing operations and represents the organisation towards the supervisory authority.
Safe lifting and moving in care Moves and supports clients using lifting technique and aids in such a way that the load on client and care worker stays limited.	Moves a client under guidance with the prescribed aid, following the instruction of the designated specialist.	Independently selects technique and aid for a client with limited mobility and instructs colleagues on the spot.	Sets the policy on physical load, analyses incident figures and brings the institution to a demonstrably lower load.
Public service delivery to citizens Handles citizens' applications and questions according to law and procedure, explains decisions understandably and keeps an eye on lead time.	Handles standard applications according to the work instruction and refers deviant cases to an experienced case handler.	Independently handles applications with exceptions, explains the outcome in plain language and monitors the deadlines.	Redesigns the service delivery processes for the whole domain and sets standards for lead time and comprehensibility.
Safety awareness Continuously watches for unsafe situations and actions at work, addresses others about them and chooses the safe working method even under time pressure.	Follows the safety rules of the workplace and checks back when in doubt about an operation.	Recognises unsafe situations in own process, intervenes and addresses colleagues without bringing the work to a halt.	Sets the safety standard for the organisation, makes safety discussable at every level and steers behaviour and culture.
Advisory skill Sharpening the question of a client and delivering a well founded recommendation in a way that the receiver adopts and implements it.	Supplies requested information and explains a standard recommendation following the fixed structure used by the team.	Reframes the question behind the question, offers two supported options with consequences and agrees a decision moment.	Advises the board on issues with conflicting interests, challenges established assumptions and safeguards the quality of advice across the organisation.

Skill	N1	N3	N5
Improvising within boundaries Devises a workable solution on the spot in an unexpected situation, staying within applicable rules, safety requirements and agreements.	Reports an unexpected situation immediately and carries out the solution the supervisor provides.	Chooses an interim solution within the rules when something fails or an unexpected request arrives, and records afterwards what deviated.	Determines how much room for improvisation the organisation allows and records which boundaries are never crossed.
Knowledge of grants and schemes Knows the conditions, deadlines and accountability requirements of grants and schemes and assesses whether an application meets them.	Checks an application for completeness against the list of conditions and requests the missing documents.	Independently assesses a complex application, tests the budget against the scheme and drafts the award decision.	Designs schemes and accountability frameworks, assesses state aid risk and advises the board on the deployment of funds.
Working with digital devices and applications Uses computers, mobile devices and standard applications to carry out work tasks, adjusts settings and resolves simple usage problems without help.	Opens and uses the prescribed applications for own tasks and asks for help whenever an unfamiliar message appears.	Selects the appropriate device and application for each task and fixes common disruptions without support from others.	Defines organisation wide which digital workplace facilities are used and guides their introduction across all teams.

6 Assessment methods and validity

The validities are the corrected meta-analytic estimates from Sackett, Zhang, Berry and Lievens (2022) in the Journal of Applied Psychology, which replace the older Schmidt and Hunter (1998) figures. The spread matters as much as the mean: with a high SD, validity varies strongly by context.

Assessment method	rho	SD	What it is
Assessment center	0.29	0.09	Multiple exercises, multiple assessors, dimension-wise scoring.
Persoonlijkheidsvragenlijst	0.40	0.15	Self-report of behavioural preferences. At hrmforce the Big Fifty and the 15PF.
Situational Judgement Test	0.12	0.11	Scenario with response options, scored on knowledge or behavioural tendency.
Praktijkobservatie	-	-	Structured workplace observation with a form based on behavioural anchors.
360 feedback	-	-	Multiple raters around the person rate behaviour against behavioural anchors.
Structureerd interview	0.42	0.19	Behaviour-based interview with fixed questions and a rating scale per question.
Portfolio/bewijsstuk	-	-	A collection of prior work or results, assessed against fixed criteria.
Werkproef	0.33	0.09	The candidate performs a representative work sample under standardised conditions.
Kennistoets	0.40	0.13	Test of declarative job knowledge, usually assembled per client.

7 Assessment instruments for this job

hrmforce instrument	Skills	What it measures
Competency Check	9	Competentiebeoordeling op gedragsniveau
Big Fifty	7	Persoonlijkheidsvragenlijst, 150 items, 25 factoren
360 Feedback	7	Meervoudige beoordeling op gedragsankers
Werkproef	6	Representatief werkfragment onder gestandaardiseerde condities
Kennistoets (klantspecifiek)	5	Toets van vakkennis, per klant samengesteld
Communicatiestijlen	2	Voorkeursstijl in communicatie
Kleurenprofiel (Jung)	2	Vier kleurentypen, gekoppeld aan Big Fifty-factoren

hrmforce instrument	Skills	What it measures
Mentale Weerbaarheid (4C)	2	Mentale weerbaarheid volgens het 4C-model
Structureerd interview	2	Gedraggericht interview met vaste opzet
Ontwikkelgesprek	2	Gestructureerd ontwikkelgesprek
Conflictstijlen	1	Voorkeursstijl in conflictsituaties
Big Fifty (schaal Integriteit)	1	
15PF	1	Persoonlijksprofiel, korter alternatief voor de Big Fifty
Pulse Survey	1	Periodieke meting op team- en organisatieniveau
Portfolio	1	Beoordeling van eerder werk tegen vaste criteria
Ability Scan	1	Capaciteitentest: verbaal, numeriek en abstract redeneervermogen

8 How to use this profile

1. Agree the profile with the hiring manager before the first candidate is measured. Weights shifted afterwards make the outcome indefensible.
2. Choose the assessment method per skill from the Assessment method column. Combine at most three methods per candidate.
3. Calibrate the assessors in a two-hour session using the anchors in chapter 5. Anchors without rater training deliver little.
4. Fill in the match calculator and discuss the gaps in the development conversation. Type A and type G are selection criteria, not one-quarter development goals.

Source: hrmforce Skills Framework 2.0, version 2.0.0, built 2026-09-08. Crosswalks to ESCO v1.2.1, O*NET 31.0, Lightcast Open Skills, SFIA 9, DigComp 3.0, EntreComp, LifeComp, GreenComp, AILit, WEF Future of Jobs 2025, ISCO-08 and the Dutch CBS occupational classification BRC 2014 edition 2025. This profile is a starting point, not a standard: align it with your own organisation before selecting on it.